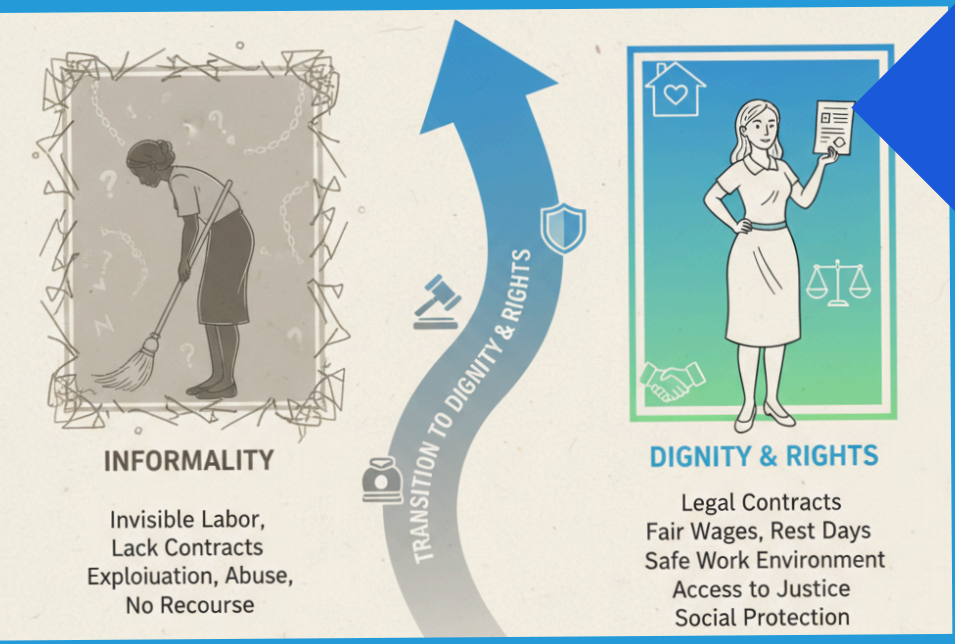
POLICY BRIEF



Advancing Legal Protections for Female Domestic Workers in Ethiopia: From Informality to Dignity and Rights

Executive Summary

Domestic work is a cornerstone of Ethiopia's economy, supporting over 1.2 million households and enabling broader workforce participation, particularly for women.

However, the sector's informality leaves an estimated 1.5 million domestic workers, predominantly young women and migrants, exposed to exploitation, including unpredictable pay, excessive working hours, and a lack of social protection.

The Ministry of Labor and Skills' Draft Regulation on Personal Service (Domestic Workers) is a critical opportunity to address this. This brief provides evidence-based recommendations to strengthen the draft, focusing on specific, actionable measures for wages, working conditions, and a feasible enforcement mechanism.

🔑 Key Recommendations

💰 Establish a National Wage Board

Set and periodically review a minimum wage for domestic work, ensuring fairness and regional relevance.

📝 Mandate a Standardized Written Contract

Require clear contracts that define working hours, rest periods, and overtime pay, protecting both employers and domestic workers.

📞 Create a Hybrid Enforcement Model

Combine a dedicated government hotline with community-based mediation through local Woreda/Kebele offices for accessible dispute resolution.

🛡️ Integrate Domestic Workers into Social Protection

Include domestic workers in existing pension and social security schemes to ensure long-term safety and dignity.

Adopting a robust regulation is not just a moral imperative but an economic one. It will formalize this vital sector, boost productivity, and demonstrate Ethiopia's commitment to international Labor standards.

Context: The Urgent Need for Formalization

Domestic work sustains Ethiopian households and the economy, yet it remains one of the most marginalized sectors.

Domestic Workers, who are often young women from rural areas, face a protection vacuum. Over 80% reported having no formal contract, leading to widespread vulnerability to abuse and unfair dismissal (Central Statistical Agency, 2022).

The Draft Regulation on Personal Service is therefore a little late but a very necessary step.

This brief builds on the multi-stakeholder consultation workshop convened by CoSAP and the Ministry of Labor and Skills in September 2025, translating the broad consensus from that event into precise recommendations to ensure the draft regulation is both transformative and practical.

Key Gaps and Specific Recommendations

Gap in Current Framework: Specific Recommendation on the Draft Regulation

💸 Vague Wage Provisions

Insert a new article mandating the establishment of a National Wages of Wage Board for Domestic Work within six months of enactment. This tripartite Board, comprising government, worker, and employer representatives, will set and annually review a regional minimum wage, accounting for the cost of living.

⏰ Unclear Working Hours & Overtime

Explicitly define a standard workweek as 48 hours, with a mandatory 24-hour rest period. Any work beyond 8 hours/day or 48 hours/week must be compensated at 1.5 times the regular hourly rate.

📄 Lack of Standardized Contracts

Develop a mandatory, simple, simple, concrete & clear Model Contract in Amharic and other local languages. This contract must specify duties, wages, work and rest hours, termination notice, and provided benefits (e.g., food, accommodation...etc).

🧭 Weak Enforcement Mechanism

Create a hybrid enforcement system:

- A free government-run hotline for complaints and information
- Designate and train Woreda/Kebele social justice officials as first-point mediators for disputes, respecting household privacy.

🛡️ Exclusion from Social Protection

Amend the regulation to require that formally registered domestic workers are enrolled in the existing national pension scheme, with contributions shared between the employer and worker at a defined rate.

Addressing Key Concerns and Building a Compelling Case

Cost to Employers and Administrative Burden

We recognize concerns about increased costs. However, formalization is an investment that reduces high turnover rates and training costs, ensuring a more stable and motivated workforce. The standardized model contract simplifies compliance, and a phased implementation plan for the minimum wage could ease the transition.

A Practical Enforcement Model

The proposed hybrid enforcement model (hotline + Woreda/Kebele mediation) is cost-effective and scalable. It moves away from the impractical model of random household inspections and instead builds on existing community structures, empowering local officials to resolve disputes before they escalate.

Addressing Key Concerns and Building a Compelling Case

The Economic and Social Imperative

Formalizing domestic work is aligned with Ethiopia's Sustainable Development Goals (SDG) commitments, particularly SDG 8 (Decent Work). It brings a significant portion of the economy into the formal sector, increasing tax base and data accuracy. By protecting a vulnerable workforce, the regulation will enhance social stability and boost the economic empowerment of women, both as workers and as employers relying on domestic support. In addition, a well-managed domestic work will feed into the country's desire to supply trained manpower to the international wage market and hence will enhance foreign currency earnings.

Conclusion and Call to Action

The Draft Regulation represents a historic opportunity to recognize the dignity and contribution of domestic workers. A strong, specific, and enforceable law is within reach.

We urge the Ministry of Labor and Skills to take the following actions:

🟦 Incorporate Key Recommendations

Integrate the proposed measures into the final draft of the regulation to ensure clarity, enforceability, and fairness

⚡ Expedite Approval and Enforcement

Facilitate swift endorsement by the Council of Ministers and ensure prompt implementation at all administrative levels

📢 Launch a Public Awareness Campaign

Educate both employers and domestic workers on their new rights and responsibilities once the regulation is enacted

🤝 Coordinate with Civil Society Organizations

Align CSO-led awareness and community mobilization efforts to reinforce understanding and application of the regulation and subsequent directives

By taking these steps, Ethiopia can establish itself as a regional leader in labor rights, creating a safer, fairer, and more productive future for all parties in the domestic work sector.

References

Central Statistical Agency, Ethiopia. (2022).Ethiopia Labor Force Survey 2021/22. Addis Ababa.

Consortium of Self help group Approach Promoters(CoSAP) (2025). Consultation Workshop Report: Draft Regulation for Personal Service (Domestic Workers). Addis Ababa

International Labor Organization. (2011). Convention C189 - Domestic Workers Convention. Geneva.

Ministry of Labor and Skills, Ethiopia. (2024). Draft Regulation on Personal Service(Domestic Workers). Addis Ababa.

Consortium of Self help group Approach Promoters (CoSAP) & Ethiopian Women Lawyers Association (EWLA). (2023). Proceeding report: Dialogue workshop on creating decent working conditions for female domestic workers in Ethiopia [Workshop report]. Packard Foundation.

Consortium of Self help group Approach Promoters (CoSAP) & Ethiopian Women Lawyers Association (EWLA). (2024). Proceeding report: Dialogue workshop on creating decent working conditions for female domestic workers in Ethiopia [Workshop report]. Packard Foundation.

CONTACT US

The Consortium of Self help group Approach Promoters (CoSAP)
Lideta Sub City, Woreda 10, African Union Area
Behind National Tobacco Enterprise
Tel: +251911255456/ +251911255653/ +251980286565

Email: cosapshg@gmail.com
www.shgconsortiumeth.org
P.O.Box 26720 code 1000 Addis Ababa, Ethiopia

Disclaimer: This document has been produced independently by CoSAP. The analysis and recommendations contained herein are solely the responsibility of the authors and do not reflect the official position or endorsement of UN Women.